Session 14. Reading Guide: The Mark of a Criminal Record

Prof. Josh Clinton

Wednesday, October 14, 2026

Read before class. Write a sentence or two for each question, from the reading.

Reading: Pager, Devah. 2003. "The Mark of a Criminal Record." *American Journal of Sociology* 108(5): 937–975.

1. Why is Pager's question difficult to answer using ordinary employment records?
2. What might differ between people with and without criminal records besides the record itself?
3. What is the treatment?
4. What is the outcome?
5. What was randomized? What was not randomized?
6. What comparison identifies the effect of a criminal record among white applicants? What comparison identifies it among Black applicants?
7. Can we identify the effect of race in exactly the same way? Why or why not?
8. Does the outcome measure whether someone was hired? Does it measure how the employer would treat the person after hiring? Does it tell us why the employer made the decision?
9. What part of employment discrimination can this outcome reveal?
10. What are the external and internal validity concerns?